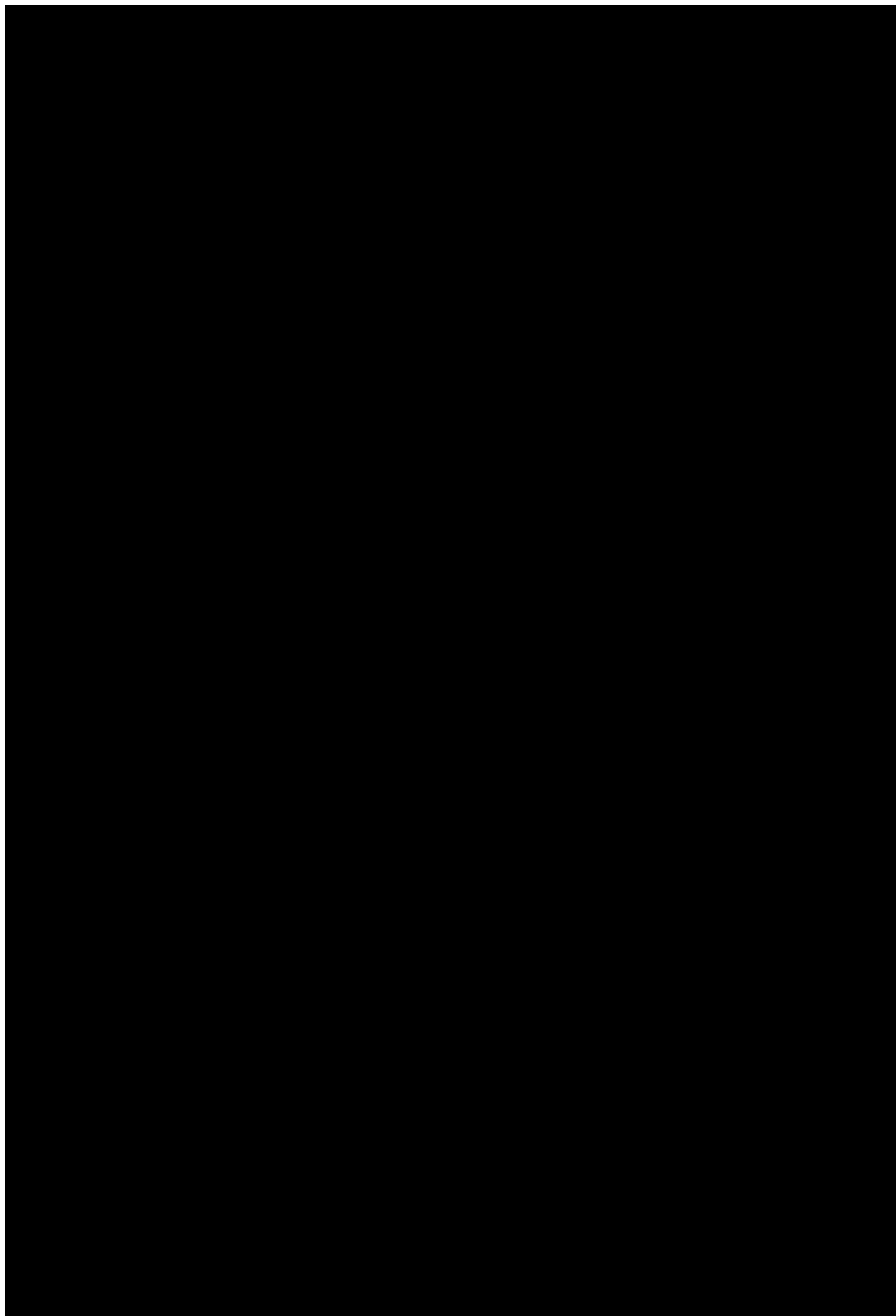




Chapter 1: Fleeing to the West

We fled Hungary in mid-November. I was unwell during the previous week and needed hospital treatment so my father, at very great risk to him, arranged for an ambulance to take my mother Magda stepfather John Schafer and me to Vrbas, to my grandparents.

Vrbas is in Northern Yugoslavia. Before the Trianon agreement it was part of Hungary, but was recently found itself cut off and ostracised by the communist regime and Tito who dared to interpret socialism in a different way was called the running dog of the imperialists.

We stayed one night only, taking no chances, and took the next train to Vienna. There we stayed in a small hotel, trotting along the famous boulevards in our large boots, going to museums, concerts and the opera house free of charge. The Austrian government welcomed us with a degree of admiration and wonder, comparing us to David who defeated Goliath. We had dared to stand up to our notorious oppressors and resist, no matter how temporarily, with our bare hands.

We were interviewed and processed and were provided with airline tickets to England, where we had guarantors, my uncle and aunt Klári.

We then spent a few days with them in Coventry, but my mother was very keen to start a new life and managed to get a job as a doctor's receptionist in Brick Lane in the East End of London.

My Mother and Step-Father in London

Magda my mother worked hard as a medical receptionist and soon she was able to put down a deposit on a fabulous double-fronted house with a romantic long garden in Wood Green. She and her husband Janos let the upper floors and part of the ground floor as well, but still had a spacious beautifully furnished flat at their disposal.

They worked extremely hard to pay for the mortgage. My mother even had to take on a factory job as a seamstress. She was not



Agathe Sorel, self-portrait, charcoal drawing, 1956

used to pressure of working on an assembly line and it sapped her health and energies. Nevertheless, they had a few good years, travelled and socialised, went to the theatre, until János's parents emigrated from Hungary and with the old ties and proximity to his mother, the problems of hysterical fits restarted. My husband Gabor was shocked to witness it, but strangely emulated this behaviour later on, maybe due to similar childhood experiences and a similar close relationship with his mother. After the death of his father, Janos's mother moved into a home for the elderly near Kew Gardens, from where she continued to interfere in her son's life, eventually wearing my mother down.

Mother by then regarded me as quite grown up and no longer her responsibility or needing special attention. She did not forget about me altogether, although I felt a bit alienated, pushed out of her life.

She had her own life and happiness to consider. She was exhausted all the time, she never experienced the pressures of an assembly line before. She was at times feeling very unwell, the jaundice she suffered back in Hungary returned and she developed cancer of the liver that spread without being diagnosed.

In autumn 1964, we received word that my grandmother Lala Mama had died. Magda packed a small rucksack and went to Vrbas for the funeral. She was by then very ill, and was advised by her GP to go to hospital immediately after her return for a biopsy and exploratory operation. They then found the cancer had spread everywhere and little could be done for her. She was operated on and was supposed to follow this up with radio, but she died in hospital within a week. They called me in during her last hours and I took my husband with me; I suppose I was afraid to face her death by myself. She saw how upset I was and with her typical toughness and lack of self-pity she said "Don't be sentimental about this. Everyone has to die". I suppose it was the shock and the realisation of my loss that caused a nose bleed which did not stop until after the funeral, when I had to be treated by a specialist.

János was devastated, but somehow carried on with the help of a housekeeper, until about 18 months later, he died of a heart attack. It transpired that he really did love my mother and was not able to carry on without her. We heard about his death after the event as we were travelling in Italy at the time and had no fixed address.

His mother Irene survived and decided she wanted to go and live with her younger son, a professor of law in the USA.

We helped her to complete all the forms at the US Embassy when

she wanted to emigrate. She was by then a widow, her husband passed away the year before. I can still see her tiny, stocky figure dressed always in black, her twisted arthritic fingers pointing out numbers when questioned by US customs officials. The gestures were so similar to those I had seen her use when bargaining for wares whilst shopping in the markets. She even tried to haggle when in department stores like John Lewis which was highly embarrassing.

She was in her mid-80s at that point. She had to answer the standard questions on the form; one of them probed whether she wanted to be a prostitute in the USA? Irene spoke virtually no English and was a simple minded but shrewd woman. We had to explain to her there and then the role of the oldest profession in the world. The official looked on with the greatest gravitas; it seems the absurdity of the situation totally escaped him.

Irene was eventually allowed to settle with her son and daughter-in-law in the Chicago area. She drove her daughter-in-law into a mental institute and then to suicide. She survived both her sons and daughters-in-law by at least ten years. Who knows, her spirit might be still alive, hovering over the world, making mischief and causing mayhem.

My Life in London

I must admit that initially, London was something of a disappointment for me. I was later to discover its unique beauty, magnificent museums, theatres and shopping centres.

Brick Lane was then a seedy, run down, and racially mixed area, which I found depressing. The streets had rather indistinguishable houses which all looked the same and the streets had a totally illogical numbering system.

I went to look at various art colleges, following introductions from Hungary to the famous art historian Professor Ernst Gombrich², the expressionist painter Carel Weight and the Hungarian engraver and painter Anthony Gross, who was a professor of printmaking at the Slade.

I found my visit to the Slade School of Art rather bewildering. I arrived in the middle of a Christmas party; loud music was playing, students were in various degrees of undress, and couples were embracing in the corridors. I was rather prim and proper and felt embarrassed. I also looked at the work, which was strangely academic and unimaginative, almost reminiscent of the academic work in Hungary.

I visited the Royal College of Art soon afterwards, which I

preferred as the work I saw on show was far more avant-garde and craft based. However, they could not take me mid-term and I would have to wait for a place.

In the meantime, I chose Camberwell School of Art and Crafts for the variety of its departments and interesting and extremely distinguished staff. There I met Michael Rothenstein⁵, RJ Kitaj⁶, Robert Medley⁷, Frank Auerbach⁸, Euan Uglow⁹, Henry Inlander¹⁰, Mario Dubsy¹¹ and Tadek Bautlich¹²; one could not imagine more inspiring company.

Soon after I started, I was asked to be an interpreter at the Royal College of Art when they interviewed a couple of my old school mates from Budapest, who did not speak English. This is how I met up again with my future husband Gabor Sitkey. I remembered him from my first college, the Academy of Applied Arts, where at the end of the corridor his group of senior students shared some of the classes with the first year cohort and were obliged to attend the early morning Marxism and Leninism seminars. His and his family's story could be found in Volume One.

I settled in at Camberwell, which suited me. I had quite a small scholarship and managed to rent a room nearby from Mrs Kendrick, who was quite a character. She still had gas stocking lighting, highly unusual at the time. The rent was £1 a week and as I had a scholarship for £2 a week, I was able to save up and to travel to Europe on a temporary travel document during the school holidays. What bliss, excitement and freedom!

Camberwell School of Arts and Craft

I was a little older than my fellow students and a little younger than most of my tutors. I started in the illustration department under Frank Martin¹³. This department included printmaking. We were allowed to use a small star wheel etching press that sat in a corner, and a beautiful old Columbian press with a golden eagle on top for woodcuts and linocuts. There was a whole room full of lithographic presses then used mostly for stone lithography. We had to hand grind the stones with different grades of sand, involving many hours of back-breaking labour. Lithographic plates were just coming into use. We were allowed downstairs into the realms of the Printing and Typography department, which was an industrial

² Sir Ernst Gombrich (1909-2001) was an Austrian-born Jewish art historian who fled Vienna for London in 1936. He was the author of many works of cultural and art history including the best seller *The Story of Art*, first published in 1950 by Phaidon

setup capable of book and newspaper production up to the highest standards of the day. Beautiful wooden type in all styles and sizes occupied the bottom drawers of the plans chests followed by lead type, which had to be melted down and re cast from time to time.

There were cut out pieces of photo gravure plates borrowed by one of the tutors from a newspaper for which he worked, but we were not allowed to use this process ourselves, because it was copyrighted! This was an extraordinary state of affairs. It would be equivalent today of someone copywriting the Internet. I did manage later to figure out and use the process to my own ends. The type was mounted together with wood engravings or photogravure and tied together with string to be rolled up and printed.

There was also the Textiles department, where you could work in silkscreen, but this was not acknowledged as a legitimate art form, it was regarded as an industrial process.

Sculpture and ceramics had their own mysterious techniques, from plaster casts to bronze casting and welding, it was all there to be discovered.

3 Carel Weight RA (1908-1997) was an English painter who served as an official War Artist during the Second World War. He taught at the Royal College of Art from 1947 until his retirement in 1973

4 Anthony Gross (1905-1984) was a British printmaker, painter, war artist and film director of Hungarian origin

5 See chapter 5 for more details about Rothenstein

6 R.B. Kitaj (1932-2007) was an American-born artist who lived in London from 1959 to 1997 and was well-known for his interest in Jewish writers and subjects

7 Robert Medley CBE, RA (1905-1994) was an English artist who painted in both abstract and figurative styles, and who also worked as theatre designer.

8 Frank Auerbach (b.1931) was born in Berlin and came to Britain alone as a child refugee from Nazism. He is a leading contemporary painter and close friend of Kitaj

9 Euan Uglow (1932-2000) was an English painter famous for his nudes

10 Henry Inlander (1925-1983) was a Viennese born painter who fled Nazism and settled in Britain in 1929. He is well known for his portraits and landscapes. He studied at Camberwell from 1945-6

11 Mario Dubsy (1939-1985) was a painter born to Viennese Jewish parents who had converted to Christianity

12 Tadek Beutlich (1922-2011) was a Polish born textile artist who studied at Camberwell and then became a visiting lecturer there

13 Frank Vernon Martin (1921-2005) was a printmaker who taught at Camberwell School of Art for 27 years. Martin proved to be an outstanding teacher, becoming Senior Lecturer in Graphic Design in 1965-76 and Head of the Department of Graphic Arts from 1976 until his retirement in 1980

Michael Rothenstein

Michael was teaching printmaking two days a week when I joined the course. He was using the large Columbian press in the corner of the illustration studio. He came to the classes with marvellous pieces of weathered wood, rescued from the flood plains of rivers or from rubbish dumps. Tadek Beutlich came in with slices of sycamore from his garden. His neighbours were rather puzzled as to why he should cut his tree in slices rather than in one go as most people do.

We scrubbed the wood with wire brushes to bring out the natural grain. The pieces were rolled up in gentle colours and printed by hand by rubbing or with plenty of packing on the Albion press. These free-standing pieces were fitted together or combined with other materials, like bits of tires or rusty pieces of metal to produce the most delicate and poetic abstract images which looked like

Michel Rothenstein
photographed in his
Studio Redstone Press





Michael Rothenstein,
Rust, xxxx, 1969

oriental calligraphy, they somehow retained the very essence of nature.

I immediately hit it off with Michael, who was somehow tolerated in spite of his eccentricities, partly because his family connections; his father Sir William Rothenstein had been a distinguished painter and principal of the Royal College of Art and his brother John Rothenstein was director of the Tate Gallery. Michael, who had very little formal art education because of a rare glandular disease, had recently returned from Paris, where he had worked with Bill Hayter for a few weeks. He admired Hayter and his methods immensely, he thought he liberated the arts and introduced totally new vistas. He did not, however, take to etching, preferring woodcuts, lino cuts and silkscreen. He had recently married Sam, his second wife, a great deal younger, who worked for J Walter Thompson the great advertising agency. It was a great love match, in spite of the fact, that Sam came from an utterly commercial background and did not really like artists. She simply did not know how to talk to them.

They lived in Great Bardfield, in a small cottage, surrounded by other well-known artists and used a flat in Beaufort Street in Chelsea when working in town. Later, they built the most amazing architect-designed house and studio in a nearby village. The house was uncompromisingly modern, even though the architect used traditional materials like flint stone and glass. It had an open plan design, with the only hiding place for Sam being a little raised area accessed by a wrought iron spiral staircase. The studio was across the open yard, with excellent facilities and storage, where a succession of technicians helped to edition his work.

It was Michael and Julian Trevelyan¹⁴ who recommended that I

Michael Rothenstein,
Black bar, xxxxxx 1962,
from our art collection
dedicated us, my
husband helped to
print it



should go to work with Hayter and I was lucky enough to win the Gulbenkian scholarship to finance this for two years.

Michael's work went from strength to strength, continuously inventing new methods and ways of expression. He was also painting and working on his famous boxes incorporating 3D elements and photography. He is now recognized as one of the most avant-garde of British printmakers. He died in 1993.

It is hard to imagine now, that amidst all this excitement and

¹⁴ Julian Trevelyan (1910-1988) was a British artist and poet. His first wife was the potter Ursula Darwin and his second wife the painter Mary Fedden



Left: Michel
Rothenstein, *Seven
colours boxes, xxxx*



Right: Michael
Rothenstein,
Moonscape boxes, xxx

creativity, life drawing and painting in the gallery world remained very conservative in outlook. The Euston Road School of realism was a kitchen sink version of social realism, painted by people who, it seemed to me, had forgotten how to clean their brushes or to prime their canvases or boards properly.

The intellectual climate was, however, very lively and lots of extremely educated and thoughtful people gathered in the staffroom or in little restaurants or artists' studios for discussions. It was felt that England at this stage was rather provincial, a cultural backwater compared with Paris or New York. It was at that stage that I went to see *The Balcony* by Jean Genet at the Arts Theatre Club in London.

Gulbenkian Fellowship

I finished my course at Camberwell and produced a small stone lithograph for my diploma work, an Illustration to a Keats poem, *An Ode to a Grecian Urn*, with an unusual technique I learnt in Hungary.

I rolled up the sensitive lithographic stone with liquid asphaltum, making it print black, and then started rubbing out gentle tones with smaller stones and charcoal, scratching into it fine details of the illustration with a thin needle. The examiners seemed to like it, despite the fact that they were unlikely to have seen anything similar before. Nevertheless, when my diploma arrived, I threw it on top of the cupboard at my digs and left it there. Later on, when the college gained university status the Ministry of Education

offered an MA certificate free of charge. I did not bother to take up the offer. What was an artist to do with such paper certificates? Oh, the conceit and arrogance of youth! It would have come useful later; when I started teaching at universities and postgraduate courses in London and Philadelphia as it would have saved me a lot of trouble in proving my credentials.

At about this time, my mother rang me one day saying that she had seen a notice in *The Times* that the Gulbenkian Foundation was advertising a scholarship for artists who wanted to work in Paris. I hurriedly sent in my application. I was interviewed by Ian Sanderson, the director of the Foundation, with whom I established a tremendous rapport and friendship that lasted for years to come.

In the face of huge competition, I won this prestigious and very generous award. First I was to go to Paris to work with the famous printmaker S.W. Hayter at the Atelier 17. I would also study French literature at the Sorbonne for two years. The scholarship was extremely generous, so I could afford the luxury of a privately rented flat near the Atelier 17 in the centre of Paris and also travel during holidays.

